Mandate

By Kelly Younger

A crowded sports bar. Two bar stools. Two drinks. One bowl of peanuts. Sounds of basketball game on TV. In the blackout, DREW shouting "C'mon! Give it to me*! You know you want to!" Then as the light comes up, we see Drew violently and awkwardly giving the Heimlich to Marc. Marc launches a peanut from his mouth. A moment of relief*

MARC: What the hell dude?

DREW: You're welcome.

MARC: I wasn't choking.

DREW: Sure you were.

MARC: I was eating a peanut.

DREW: That got lodged in your throat.

MARC: Not until you started crushing my lungs.

DREW: Wait, seriously? You weren't choking?

MARC: That's what I was trying to say but you were shouting and thrusting. Where did you learn the Heimlich, prison?

DREW: *(hands to throat)* You gave the universal sign for choking.

MARC: I was just adjusting my collar. I told you I was coming straight from a haircut.

DREW: Well, it looks great.

MARC: Thanks?

DREW: Guess that was pretty awkward.

MARC: Yeah. Awkward.

DREW: But you're fit, man. *(poking him)* Could feel a pretty tight little core while I was squeezing you.

MARC: Not any less awkward.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Men befriending men — it sounds like a simple endeavor,*
ACTOR 2: *But after 200,000 years on the planet, American men appear to be stuck in a "friendship recession"*
ACTOR 1: *In a 2021 survey, less than half of the men said they were truly satisfied with how many friends they had,*
ACTOR 2: *While 15 percent said they had no close friends at all — a fivefold increase since 1990.*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

ACTOR 1: *That same survey found that men were less likely than women to rely on their friends for emotional support or to share their personal feelings with them.*
ACTOR 2: *But not today . . . A humorous (but oh, so true) look into the*
TOGETHER: *Mandate by Kelly Younger*

DREW: I put on some sympathy weight when Hillary first got pregnant-with Addison. She used to say we were having twins. One in her belly, one in mine. Then when we had Bridgie I was like, bring on the sweatpants! *(MARC lifts his drink, DREW quickly follows and overeagerly cheers him, almost smashing his mug.)* Here's to good friends. Tonight is kind of special. *(MARC doesn't really know how to respond.)*

MARC: So, Beth told me you're a teacher.

DREW: Earth science and driver's ed. 124 kids. All girl's school.

MARC: All girls. That's a lot.

DREW: Don't have to tell me. But I can text 90 words in 2 minutes 26 seconds, so, you know, I'm kind of a popular teacher. And I know the words to every *One Direction* song. Go on. Try me.

MARC: With what?

DREW: *One Direction* challenge.

MARC: I don't know what that is.

DREW: Seriously? They're like *the Monkees* for the new generation. *(singing, throwing out boy-band gestures)* You don't know you're beautiful! Oh-oh! That's what

MARC: *(cutting him off)* Jake's kind of more into *Star Wars.*

DREW: Ah, man. I'd give anything to have a son. Don't get me wrong, I love my girls. I'm just, you know, kind of out numbered. I brought out all my old action figures and the girls just wanted to have a pool party with Barbie and I was like, Bobo Fet does not swim.

MARC: He's way into it. I do this funny thing with Jake, whenever we go through the security gate at our condo, it opens automatically, but I put my hand up like a Jedi and act like I'm giving it a force push, and when it opens, you should see his face. *(Long moment)*

DREW: *(with deep admiration)* You're amazing.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MARC: I'm sure you do loads of stuff like that.

DREW: Addison and Bridgie paint my toe nails. In fact, my toenails are always painted. Wanna see?

MARC: I'm good.

DREW: Cool.

MARC: Cool. *(A moment)*

DREW: Can I tell you a secret?

MARC: I think you just did.

DREW: I'm a brony.

MARC: A what?

DREW: A bro who likes My Little Pony.

MARC: That's a thing?

DREW: Huge. My girls got me hooked. We threw a party for the coronation episode where Princess Celestia finally gave Twilight Sparkle her wings. Man. That was a great night. *(beat)* Friendship is magic. *(MARC takes a drink and DREW mirrors his every move.)* This is nice. I'm really glad our wives set this up.

MARC: *(focusing on the game)* Yeah.

DREW: They totally knew we'd get along. And it's so hard, you know, with work and kids and everything, I mean, how do people even make friends anymore? Especially guys, you know? Like there's no way guys just become friends like you did in college. Had a class together or in a frat or something. Now it's all about do the spouses get along, and what if they do but their kid is a *jerk* or the kids get along but the parents are *jerks* and do you want to be best friends?

MARC: *(beat)* What's that?

DREW: Do you want to be my best friend? *(MARC laughs, then stops.)*

MARC: You're serious.

DREW: I mean, like, unless you've already got one. Do you?

MARC: A best friend?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DREW: And wives don't count. I'm talking guy best friends. You already have one?

MARC: Dude. I haven't really thought about it like that since

DREW: Since what?

MARC: Grade school.

DREW: So do ya?

MARC: I've got plenty of friends.

DREW: Not counting work.

MARC: Ok, yeah.

DREW: And not counting dads from your kid's school.

MARC: Ok. Yeah, still got 'em.

DREW: And not counting guys from college. Or Facebook.

MARC: Well who's left? You basically eliminated all my social circles.

DREW: Hillary's got like ten best girlfriends and they go out and they talk on the phone every day and confide in one another and chat about work and yoga and how their bodies are changing. And this ... this is what guys should talk about, right?

MARC: *(thinking)* No.

DREW: But our wives do all the time about everything and I mean everything like shopping and gossip and your yeast infection.

MARC: You know about that? And it was not a yeast infection. *(subtly adjusting his crotch)* It was a fungus.

DREW: Made of yeast. But don't be embarrassed bro, it happens. You just gotta wash better after the gym.

MARC: Dude. I don't need your hygiene advice. Can we please just watch the Lakers?

DREW: Oh. Are we moving too fast? Or you already have a best friend?

MARC: No. I mean, yeah . . . that's right, I do.

DREW: Who?

MARC: The best man at our wedding. JD. He lives in Baltimore now.

DREW: How often do you guys talk?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MARC: Enough. I guess.

DREW: Like, once a week, or what?

MARC: Like . . . I don't know. I guess- *(beat)* Huh. When was the last time I talked to him?

DREW: See? He was your best man and you don't even talk anymore.

MARC: We don't have to. He's just the kind of guy that just, you know, we don't need to talk a lot.

DREW: I'm not like that.

MARC: Really.

DREW: And I don't think most guys are either, we just think we're supposed to act that way.

MARC: Didn't you have a best man?

DREW: Hillary's brother. He doesn't like me all that much. Thinks I come on too strong.

MARC: *(beat)* Look, Drake.

DREW: Drew.

MARC: Sorry. Drew. Listen, Beth told me her friend from yoga ... your wife ... had a cool husband and we should meet up and I said, ok, sure, thinking we would just, you know, meet up, but, all this best friends forever kinda thing is just a little ... I'm just not really ... in the market for one, you know?

DREW: *(beat)* That's cool.

MARC: Let's just watch the game, be guys. In silence. *(DREW plays it off. They both watch the game. Then Drew takes out a small pink notebook and pen, scratches something out.)* What's that? *(eyeing his pad)* Did you just cross my name off of some ... list? What is this? *(picking up pad, reading)* "Possible candidates for my new best friend." *(He flips through pages. Clearly, a long list.)* How many ... I'm at the bottom? Dave Scales is on here? That guy's a tool. How is he higher up on the list than me?

DREW: What's it matter now? I've run out of names.

MARC: Wait, seriously, you've done this with all these guys?

DREW: And none of them ever called for a second date.

MARC: Maybe because you're calling it a date.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DREW: What would you call it?

MARC: Just ... hanging out. Getting to know each other. Kind of like ... kind of like ... yeah, I guess ... *(Stands, begins to pull wallet out.)* Look. You seem like a great guy.

DREW: Here we go again.

MARC: But it's not really a great time for me, right now, and I . . . what's happening? *(DREW's trying to keep it together, holding back tears. MARC eyes him, then DREW starts to lose it. MARC looks around. Clearly they have everyone's attention.)* You ok? Hey. Buddy.

DREW: *(through snot)* I'm not your buddy. You've made that perfectly clear.

MARC: Woah. Seriously, pal.

DREW: *(losing it)* I'm not your pal either. Or your amigo. Or your dawg. Or Edgar Allen Bro. I used to be fun. Guys used to beg to hang out with me. But now I'm on list-serves with mommy and me groups. The last sporting event I went to was a Silpada jewelry party. I've become this overweight, pathetic, whiskered . . . You gotta help me! *(He collapses into MARC, a blubbering mess. MARC is stunned, embarrassed, trapped. But then he pats DREW on the back.)*

MARC: There there. *(But DREW is still weeping. This time, MARC actually pats him with sincerity, gently holding the big lug.)* Hey. It's ok. It's going to be ok. *(DREW eventually pulls himself together, embarrassed. He pats under his eyes with his ring fingers.)*

DREW: Ok. I'm ok. I'm all right.

MARC: Look, man. I get it.

DREW: You're just saying that because I snotted on your sweater vest.

MARC: No, seriously. I do. I mean. If you asked me in high school if I would even be the kind of guy who wore sweater vests, I would have laughed right in your face. You think I wanted to grow up and be this sorry cubicle jockey who works sixty hours a week pushing numbers around? You want to hear something sad? The only thing I excel at ... is Excel. I make good spreadsheets. That's it. And my freaking life has become this massive, over-organized spreadsheet with cells that just go on and on and on. It never ends. And it's sucking the life out of me, one spread-sheet at a time. *(Bites his lip.)* Damnit. You're gonna make me cry

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

now.

DREW: It's ok. Spreadsheets are hard.

MARC: They're really hard!

DREW: But it feels better to talk about, doesn't it. *(A moment. MARC nods.)*

MARC: Look. I don't have a lot of time right now, with work and the kids and all, and, I don't know if I'm like best friend material here or anything but ... you can keep my name on the list ... if you want. And I'll ... you know ... I'll call you ... for a second, you know, whatever this is. And maybe we can try it again. See where it goes. Cool?

DREW: Cool. *(They both stare forward in silence, watching the game. A big, delighted grin grows across DREW's face.)* We totally need nicknames

MARC: We totally do not.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kelly Younger
Book: Best Ten-Minute Plays 2014; Pg 100-107
ISBN: 978-1575258867
Publisher: Smith and Kraus
Date (Month/Year): June 2014

AWARD HISTORY

NIETOC
IL State Qualifier

Introduction Statistics derived from
The State of American Friendship: Change, Challenges, and Loss Findings from the May 2021 American Perspectives Survey June 8, 2021 by Daniel A. Cox

https://www.americansurveycenter.org/research/the-state-of-american-friendship-change-challenges-and-loss/

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY